

LONGER CAREERS, FEWER OPPORTUNITIES



57% OF WORKERS AGED 18-26 RECEIVED A RECENT PROMOTION, COMPARED WITH 22% OF THOSE 65+.

14% OF WORKERS AGED 65+ STRONGLY BELIEVE THEIR EMPLOYER INVESTS IN SKILLS THEY NEED FOR FUTURE GROWTH, COMPARED WITH 23% OF WORKERS AGED 18-26.

54% OF WORKERS AGED 18-26 EXPECT A PROMOTION WITHIN THE NEXT YEAR, COMPARED WITH ONLY 26% OF THOSE AGED 55-64 AND 17% OF EMPLOYEES AGED 65+.

23% OF WORKERS AGED 65+ STRONGLY BELIEVE THEY HAVE THE SKILLS TO MOVE TO THE NEXT LEVEL, DESPITE DECADES OF EXPERIENCE, COMPARED WITH 32% OF THOSE AGED 18-26.

65

SOURCE ADP'S PEOPLE AT WORK 2026 REPORT

need for future career growth, compared with 23% of employees aged 18-26.

Career progression reflects the same trend. Nearly 57% of college graduates aged 18-26 report receiving a recent promotion, compared with 40% of employees aged 40-54, 30% of those aged 55-64 and just 22% of workers aged 65 and above. Expectations of future advancement decline just as sharply, from 54% among younger graduates to only 26% of employees aged 55-64 and 17% among those over 65. The uncertainty extends beyond career progression to the external job market.

Nearly half (47%) of college-educated employees aged 65 and above believe changing jobs has become harder over the past year, compared with 43% of workers aged 18-26. While 16% of younger graduates believe changing jobs has become easier, only 4% of workers aged 65 and above agree.

Four in ten college-educated employees aged 65 and above believe job opportunities are neither improving nor worsening, suggesting they see the labour market as increasingly static rather than expanding.

Experienced professionals remain committed to

work yet feel increasingly uncertain about their future both within organisations and in the broader labour market.

EXPERIENCE AND HIRING

If older professionals are growing less confident about their career prospects, employers appear to be moving in the opposite direction. Neeti Sharma, CEO of Team-Lease Digital, says age is gradually becoming less of a hiring barrier, although it has not disappeared entirely. "Today, employers are looking less at someone's age and more at whether they can adapt, learn and stay relevant," she says. "Skill shortages are making companies value the experience, stability and mentoring that senior professionals bring, particularly in areas such as AI, cybersecurity, Global Capability Centres and consulting."

Age bias has not disappeared. Around 15-20% of professionals still report experiencing age discrimination. But Sharma believes the hiring conversation is shifting from years of experience to the ability to evolve. That shift is reflected in the growing demand for business